Protecting the Lie: A Confirmation-Based Reconceptualization of Narcissistic Supply

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Abstract

"Narcissistic supply" is conventionally described as the attention, admiration, fear, sympathy, or obedience that a narcissistic person extracts from others, and narcissism is often glossed as an addiction to such supply. This paper argues that the conventional account inverts the causal structure it describes: the person does not maintain a false self in order to obtain supply; they seek supply because it protects the false self. At the center of the narcissistic organization is a Protected Identity Proposition: a self-defining claim (I am superior; I am innocent; I am the real victim; my failures are caused by others) that is treated as necessary for identity coherence and is exempted from ordinary belief revision. The defining feature is not that the claim is false but that it is not allowed to lose. On this model, supply is a social signal interpreted as indicating that the protected claim remains uncontested or socially enforceable, which explains why supply never satisfies, why credible contradiction provokes disproportionate defense, and why hedonically opposite supplies (admiration and pity) substitute for one another. DARVO-type responses are reframed as a recurrent family of identity-protection operations. The construct is positioned as a specification of the overvalued idea: one about the self's standing, maintained by other people's silence and enlarged by its own defenses. Six testable predictions are stated, including one already challenged by existing evidence, and the cleanest is worked through as a full experimental design that separates identity-diagnosticity from ordinary aversiveness. Corrigibility, operationally defined as revision under evidence minus revision under pressure, is proposed as the treatment-relevant outcome variable.

Keywords: narcissism; narcissistic supply; ego threat; DARVO; belief revision; identity; corrigibility

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1. The problem with "supply"

The term "narcissistic supplies" entered the literature with Fenichel (1938), who described external provisions of affection and approval required by an ego that cannot regulate self-esteem internally. In the decades since, and especially in the last twenty years, the term has migrated out of the clinic into popular psychology and survivor communities, where it now names a commodity: the attention the narcissist is supposedly after. On this received view the narcissist is a consumer of psychological fuel, and the familiar metaphors follow: the empty cup, the bottomless tank, the addict chasing a fix. Baumeister and Vohs (2001) made the addiction version explicit in the academic literature, proposing that narcissism operates as an addiction to esteem, complete with a tolerance pattern in which ever larger doses are required.

The received view has real strengths. It predicts approach behavior (narcissists seek audiences), it predicts distress under deprivation, and it gives victims a usable heuristic: become a boring source and the extraction stops. Any successor account must keep these successes. But the fuel picture mistakes the fuel for the engine, and three well-documented phenomena fit it badly.

2. Three anomalies

Insatiability. Fuel models predict satiation: a tank, once filled, stays full for a while. Clinical descriptions from Kernberg (1975) onward converge on the observation that admiration does not accumulate; yesterday's triumph is inert today. The addiction variant answers with tolerance, and commits to a specific curve: larger doses should restore relief. What clinicians describe is closer to reassurance dynamics: relief that decays rapidly regardless of dose, because the underlying threat is untouched by the reassurance. Tolerance and reassurance decay are quantitatively distinguishable, and this difference is testable.

The response to contradiction. On the fuel picture, criticism is a supply interruption, and the predicted response is renewed extraction elsewhere. What is actually observed is a stereotyped emergency repertoire: deny the evidence, discredit the witness, rewrite the history, attack the critic, reverse victim and offender. Freyd (1997) named the core of this pattern DARVO, and experimental work shows it is effective: exposure to DARVO responses reduces perceived perpetrator responsibility and victim credibility (Harsey & Freyd, 2020). A fuel interruption does not by itself explain why the witness is discredited rather than merely replaced. The effort devoted to discrediting the witness suggests that contradiction may threaten something more structural than the interruption of a rewarding social signal.

Substitutability of opposites. Admiration and pity are hedonic opposites; being feared and being comforted are hedonic opposites. Yet the same person switches between harvesting them, a pattern now central to the structural literature on grandiose and vulnerable presentations (Pincus et al., 2009; Krizan & Herlache, 2018). A fuel model must flatten all of these into "attention." Whatever unifies them is not how they feel; it is what they signal.

3. The Protected Identity Proposition

The model proposed here locates the center of the narcissistic organization not in an appetite but in a proposition.

Definition. A Protected Identity Proposition (PIP) is a self-relevant claim, held not merely as a revisable description but as constitutive of identity coherence, that satisfies two conditions:

1. Load-bearing. The claim's continued standing is treated as necessary for the self to hold together. The felt alternative to the claim is not "I was wrong" but self-dissolution: annihilating shame.
2. Exemption from revision. The claim is defended through asymmetric standards of evidence, witness management, and resistance to correction. Evidence against it is not weighed; it is handled. In short: the belief is not allowed to lose.

Falsity is deliberately not a defining condition. A researcher cannot decisively score the truth of "I am unusually intelligent" or "I am usually treated unfairly," and does not need to. The pathology is located in the closed correction process, not in a truth value. Falsity is the typical consequence rather than the criterion: a claim that can never lose drifts from the evidence, because whatever error it contains can never be removed. The model thereby covers exaggerations, selective truths, and unfalsifiable stories as readily as clean falsehoods.

Why "lie," then. Version 1.1 of this paper used the word in two senses at once: the construct did not require falsity, yet the claim was said to "function as a lie" downstream. The word is now kept in one sense only, and that sense concerns history and function, not current truth value. On the developmental account proposed in a companion paper (Roonz, 2026), a protected proposition typically becomes one by being defended: it begins as an exaggeration, a convenient story, or a self-serving account offered under threat, and each defense of it that comes to be believed joins it, until the account is held as true and exempt from revision. "Lie" names that origin (a claim maintained against the evidence available when it was defended) and that function (a claim others cannot correct). It is not a verdict on whether the claim is true today, which may be unknowable. The origin is a hypothesis about how such propositions form, not part of the definition: the defining conditions remain the two above, and both can be assessed without scoring truth. In the academic register the construct is the PIP, and nothing in the predictions depends on the word.

The narcissistic configuration. Protected Identity Propositions are not proposed as unique to narcissism and may represent a transdiagnostic mechanism of identity-protective cognition. Their narcissistic configuration is marked by the content and interpersonal organization of the protected claim: exceptional status, entitlement, innocence, blamelessness, or exemption from reciprocal accountability; dependence on other people as confirmation instruments; and recurrent efforts to control witnesses, records, and moral roles when the claim is challenged. The model therefore does not define narcissism by revision resistance alone, but by the organization of revision resistance around privileged self-status and interpersonal asymmetry.

Relation to the overvalued idea. The nearest construct in descriptive psychopathology is the overvalued idea, first described by Wernicke (1900): in McKenna's (1984) summary, a solitary, abnormal belief, neither delusional nor obsessional, that preoccupies the person to the point of dominating their life. Veale (2002) reads overvalued ideas as idealized values so overriding that they come to define the self, and are held rigidly. Forensic psychiatry has extended the idea to extreme overvalued beliefs that are shared within a group and defended with intense emotional commitment (Rahman, Resnick, & Harry, 2016). A Protected Identity Proposition plausibly belongs to this family; the transdiagnostic remark above already points there. What the construct adds is specific:

1. **Content.** The protected claim concerns the self's standing (superiority, innocence, entitlement, blamelessness), not a value about the world, the body, or a group's cause.
2. **Interpersonal maintenance.** It is held in place by other people, because it needs them to keep not contradicting it. This generates supply-seeking as confirmation and the management of witnesses and records, which accounts of overvalued ideas do not predict.

3. **A signature.** Within the protected domain the person yields to pressure and resists evidence (Section 5), and defense tracks how much of the claim a contradiction would falsify rather than its social cost (Section 6, prediction 2).
4. **A history.** The proposition grows through its own defenses, as described above.

In short, a Protected Identity Proposition is proposed as an overvalued idea about the self's standing, maintained by other people's silence and enlarged by its own defenses. That claim is itself testable. If the predictions in Section 6 are fully explained by existing accounts of overvalued ideas with defensive elaboration, the construct adds nothing and should be retired into them.

Supply, redefined. Because the proposition must be maintained regardless of what the evidence does, reality bears on it continuously: every ordinary failure, every unimpressed stranger, every accurate memory held by another person is a standing challenge that cannot be metabolized as an update. A revision-exempt claim therefore generates a permanent defense workload, and supply is one of the two currencies that pay for it. Supply is a social signal interpreted as indicating that the protected proposition remains uncontested or socially enforceable. Praise is read as superiority standing; obedience as entitlement standing; fear as power standing; sympathy as innocence standing; even persecution is read as victimhood standing. Two precisions matter. First, confirmation is the organization's reading of the signal, not a property of the signal: praise is not evidence of superiority, and the model never treats it as such. Second, "socially enforceable" carries weight: it is not necessary that others sincerely believe the proposition, only that nobody can successfully challenge it, which is why intimidation, institutional power, and silence can substitute for sincere admiration.

This redefinition explains the three anomalies at once. Supply cannot satiate because it is a perimeter report, not a stored resource: its value decays at the rate at which the environment re-presents challenges, which is continuous. Contradiction provokes disproportionate response because it is not lost fuel but a structural threat to the claim holding the self together. And opposite supplies substitute because they confirm different clauses of the same protected proposition; when superiority becomes indefensible in a given audience, the innocence clause is activated and the harvested signal switches from admiration to sympathy. The surface behavior reverses; the function is continuous.

4. The protection operations

The second currency is active handling of disconfirming signals and their sources. The defense repertoire decomposes into five operations: deny the evidence; discredit the witness; rewrite the history; attack and reverse the moral roles; and manage witnesses preemptively (gaslighting, isolation, control of shared records; on gaslighting as a structural phenomenon see Sweet, 2019). The first four, run under acute threat, constitute DARVO with the history-revision step made explicit.

The claim here is stated carefully. DARVO is proposed as a recurrent family of identity-protection operations, with selection and ordering shaped by whether earlier operations neutralize the contradiction. Whether the sequence is genuinely ordered, and how often stages are skipped, combined, or entered mid-sequence, is an empirical question for transition analysis, not an assumption. And the operations are not

exclusive to narcissism: institutions, frightened children, and ordinary people under acute threat use some of them. The proposed discriminator is never the presence of the operations but their profile: frequency, rigidity across contexts, deployment at low stakes, insensitivity to the quality of the contradicting evidence, and persistence after the contradiction has been withdrawn.

5. The corrigibility signature

Ordinary self-serving cognition resists evidence imperfectly and yields to it eventually (Festinger, 1957; Kunda, 1990). The model's prediction is comparative and domain-bound: relative to controls, narcissistic pathology should show greater revision in response to status and interpersonal pressure and reduced revision in response to evidence, specifically within domains connected to a protected proposition. Outside those domains, revision behavior may be unremarkable. Nothing here claims a global inability to reason.

Components of this signature are already in the literature: narcissists attend more to feedback's valence than its validity; grandiose narcissists rate negative feedback as less diagnostic, revise less after expert advice, remain confident after being shown wrong, and externalize blame for failures; and aggression after ego threat targets the source of the threat specifically rather than bystanders (Bushman & Baumeister, 1998). The present contribution is not any of these observations but their assembly into a single signature: within the protected domain, the organization yields to pressure and resists evidence, which is the reverse of ordinary epistemic conduct. The signature also separates the model from a cynical-manipulator account: a pure manipulator updates privately while managing appearances; the prediction here is that the narcissistic organization does not perform the private update, because the proposition is identity rather than strategy.

6. Predictions

1. **Decay, not tolerance.** In experience-sampling data, relief after supply events should decay rapidly and dose-insensitively (reassurance dynamics), rather than showing the escalating-dose pattern the addiction model predicts. The distinctive prediction is coupling: decay and relief should track the match between the event and the person's specific protected claims, not general reassurance dependence, which is what discriminant comparisons (anxiety, reassurance-seeking, rejection sensitivity, contingent self-worth) must rule out.

2. **Diagnosticity over social cost.** Defense magnitude should scale with how much of the protected claim a contradiction would falsify if credited, not with the contradiction's rudeness or social cost. A low-status critic with documentation should provoke more defense than a high-status critic delivering an irrelevant insult. This is the cleanest of the six predictions and the one to pilot first; Section 9 works it through as a full design.

3. **Credibility, consequence, and attackability.** Defensive urgency should increase with a witness's credibility and ability to make the contradiction socially consequential. The selected protection operation should depend on perceived attackability: an attackable witness may be discredited directly, whereas a powerful witness may prompt strategic compliance, withdrawal, audience-switching, delayed retaliation, or private devaluation.

4. **Substitutability.** Supplies should be interchangeable when matched for confirmation content and non-substitutable when the operative clause changes; presentation switching (grandiose to vulnerable) should co-occur with a switch in which clause is under threat.

5. **Self-affirmation boundary conditions.** The model originally predicted that affirmation in an unrelated domain (Steele, 1988) would fail to reduce narcissistic defense. Existing evidence already counts against the strong form of this prediction: Thomaes and colleagues (2009) found that a values-affirmation exercise reduced narcissistic aggression in a randomized field experiment with adolescents. The prediction therefore survives only as a boundary-condition test: the model expects affirmation's protective effect to weaken toward the pathological range, under contradiction that is diagnostic of a specific protected claim rather than generic insult, and on belief-revision and witness-discrediting outcomes rather than aggression. If affirmation attenuates defense under those conditions as well, this component of the model fails. The challenge is stated here deliberately, as a receipt.

6. **Contradiction over deprivation.** Given a choice, the organization should prefer deprivation (no audience) to exposure to credible correction; a starving perimeter is better than a breached one. Fuel models predict the opposite preference.

7. Relation to existing accounts

The model is a functional refinement of existing theory, not a replacement, and its components are individually precedented. Fenichel's original supplies were needed because internal structure was missing. Kohut's (1971) mirroring selfobject is a confirmation channel. Kernberg (1975) supplied the structural core of grandiosity as defense. Morf and Rhodewalt's (2001) dynamic self-regulatory model, the nearest neighbor, already treats narcissism as a system of strategies for maintaining a grandiose self; Back and colleagues' (2013) admiration and rivalry pathways already subordinate both charm and aggression to grandiosity maintenance; and Grapsas and colleagues' (2020) status-pursuit model already identifies what is most often pursued. The present proposal differs in specifying what is being maintained (a proposition exempted from revision, rather than esteem, status, or a self-image in general), what supply is (a perimeter report rather than a consumable), and what recovery would be (restored corrigibility rather than replenished esteem). Status, admiration, and esteem may all be genuinely pursued; the claim is that their value varies with their function in preserving revision-exempt propositions, and the predictions above are designed to test whether that functional layer does independent work. Outside personality psychology, the nearest neighbor is the overvalued idea, discussed in Section 3. A recent systematic review of subclinical narcissism frames "everyday narcissism" as a self-regulatory system sustained by validation seeking, entitlement, and status preservation (Ward, 2026). The present model is a proposal about what that system regulates: a proposition exempted from revision.

8. Clinical implication, stated as hypothesis

If the model is correct, esteem support and supply management may be insufficient unless they ultimately increase corrigibility, the capacity to let evidence revise a self-defining account. Therapeutic improvement

should track the degree to which self-relevant correction becomes tolerable and usable. Shame tolerance may be a prerequisite, because the barrier to revision is the forecast of annihilation. This also yields a prognostic reading of the alliance: the therapist is a high-credibility witness, so idealization while confirming and devaluation precisely when most accurate are what the model expects, and rupture timing becomes data. These are hypotheses for treatment research, not established findings. The outcome measure they imply is concrete: not how the person shines, but what they do when accurately, credibly, and kindly contradicted.

An operational definition. Corrigibility needs a measure before it can serve as a treatment target, and the signature in Section 5 supplies one. Corrections to the person's own elicited self-claims are scored in two matched kinds: corrections backed by evidence the person can inspect (a record, a document, their own earlier statement, a third party's account offered with its source), and corrections backed only by pressure (assertion, status, or insistence without evidence). Each correction is scored on three things: whether the person acknowledges it; how far their stated confidence in the claim changes; and whether the revised account is still the one they give at the next session. **Corrigibility is revision under evidence minus revision under pressure.** A corrigible person yields to evidence and resists pressure, so the index is positive. Within the protected domain the model predicts the reverse, a negative index, and treatment success is the index moving toward positive, specifically on protected claims. In a therapy session only the evidence arm is used: evidence-backed corrections arise naturally, and pressure-backed corrections must not be manufactured clinically. The pressure arm belongs to research analogues, where it is scored against matched evidence-backed corrections. Trait intellectual humility (Leary et al., 2017) is the natural convergent measure, and recent work supplies a first empirical anchor. In two correlational studies, antagonistic and neurotic narcissism were strongly negatively related to independence of intellect and ego, the capacity to keep disagreement from registering as a personal threat. All three narcissism facets were associated with greater intellectual overconfidence, while agentic narcissism showed modest positive links to openness (Zajenkowski et al., 2025). That is the shape the model expects: the deficit sits with the antagonistic and vulnerable components, and it concerns disagreement experienced as threat. The studies are correlational and did not observe revision behavior, which is what the index above would add.

9. A worked design: diagnosticity over social cost

Prediction 2 has the cleanest logic of the six, and its difficulty is the confound named in Section 10: a contradiction that threatens a person's protected claim is usually also more unpleasant, so a larger defensive response could reflect aversiveness rather than diagnosticity. The design below separates the two by holding the stimulus constant and letting only its relation to the recipient vary.

Why the threat must be claim-specific. A preregistered Trier Social Stress Test study (N = 161 men) found no compelling evidence that narcissism, in any of its facets, moderated psychological or physiological stress reactivity to social-evaluative threat (Stern et al., 2025). That null result constrains the model in a useful way. The model predicts heightened defense under contradiction of a specific protected claim, not under evaluation as such, so the null is consistent with it; but it counts against any reading of the model as a general hypersensitivity to judgment, and the authors note that it questions "fragile self"

accounts. Generic evaluative threat is therefore the wrong manipulation, which is why the design targets each participant's own claims.

Participants. Adults sampled across the range of pathological narcissism (e.g., the PNI; Pincus et al., 2009) rather than in extreme groups, so that narcissism enters as a continuous moderator. Sample size is set by a preregistered power analysis from pilot effect sizes.

Session 1: elicitation and pre-rating. Each participant completes the structured self-claim interview proposed in the companion research program: their identity-level claims, and for each claim, their confidence, what evidence would revise it, and how they expect to feel if it were revised. Claims for which no revising evidence can be named, and whose revision is forecast in annihilating terms, are candidate protected claims. Claims held confidently but revisably serve as comparison claims. Each participant also rates a standard bank of feedback statements for how unpleasant each would be to receive.

Stimulus construction: yoked pairs. Participants are paired. For each pair, feedback statements are written that contradict a protected claim of participant A, and statements that contradict a protected claim of participant B. Each participant receives both sets, framed as feedback about themselves. A statement written against A's protected claim is identity-diagnostic for A; for B, the same sentence concerns a matter B does not stake their identity on. The same sentences are delivered across the pair, so wording, length, tone, and content are identical. Only diagnosticity differs, and it differs in opposite directions for the two partners. Statements are additionally matched on each recipient's own pre-rated unpleasantness, so that, within each person, the diagnostic and non-diagnostic feedback do not differ in how unpleasant the person expected them to be.

Session 2: delivery, crossed with social cost. Each participant receives diagnostic and non-diagnostic feedback under high social cost (from a high-status evaluator, with an audience) and low social cost (privately, from a peer), in a counterbalanced 2 × 2 within-person design. Social cost is varied only through the delivery context, never through the wording, so that yoking is preserved.

Measures. After each item: derogation of the source (rated credibility and competence); denial and reinterpretation (coded open-ended responses); belief revision (change in confidence in the targeted claim); and felt unpleasantness at the moment of delivery (the manipulation check). Heart rate and salivary cortisol are an informative addition, because they allow a direct comparison with the generic-threat null above: the model predicts physiological reactivity that tracks diagnosticity, where generic evaluation produced none that tracked narcissism. One week later: recall of the feedback, coded for self-favouring distortion, and whether any revision persisted.

Analysis and failure conditions. Multilevel models with items nested in participants and participants nested in pairs. The model predicts a larger effect of diagnosticity than of social cost on source derogation, denial, and recall distortion; a smaller effect on belief revision; and a diagnosticity effect that grows with narcissism. The critical test controls for felt unpleasantness measured at delivery. Prediction 2 fails if the diagnosticity effect disappears once felt unpleasantness is controlled, because aversiveness would then explain the defense. It also fails if social cost predicts defense as well as or better than diagnosticity.

Ethics. False feedback aimed at a protected claim is distressing by design. The protocol requires full debriefing, a demonstration that the feedback was fabricated, mood repair, and exclusion of participants at clinical risk. For clinical samples, a milder analogue (vignettes built from the participant's own claims, rated rather than received) may be the most an ethics board should approve.

10. Limitations

This is a theoretical proposal. Its constructs require validation: the protected proposition must be identified per person (a structured elicitation interview is proposed in the companion research program), and self-report will be least reliable at exactly the point being measured, so behavioral, informant, and longitudinal validation are required. The hardest methodological problem is separating identity-diagnosticity from ordinary aversiveness in contradiction paradigms. Section 9 proposes a yoked design that holds the stimulus constant and controls felt unpleasantness. If the diagnosticity effect does not survive that control, the model's central predictions fail. One prediction is already challenged by existing evidence and has been narrowed accordingly. Finally, the reconceptualization applies to narcissistic personality organization across the spectrum, with strong claims reserved for the pathological range; it does not claim that every self-serving bias is narcissism, and it does not authorize diagnosing individuals at a distance.

11. Conclusion

The supply construct survives, demoted and clarified: supply is real, sought, and harvested, but it is the perimeter report of a defended proposition, not the commodity of an appetite. Narcissism, on this account, is not an addiction to attention. It is an organized refusal of reality, and supply is whatever helps keep the refusal intact. The engine is a self-defining proposition that has been removed from reality's correction process. The belief is not allowed to lose; everything else follows from that.

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